

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global data · 2023 · Public Health Policy Focus

For Public Health Policy Analysts & Mental Health Program Planners

Source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease Study (2025)

Hundreds of Millions Affected

1 in 3

Women face major depression

1 in 5

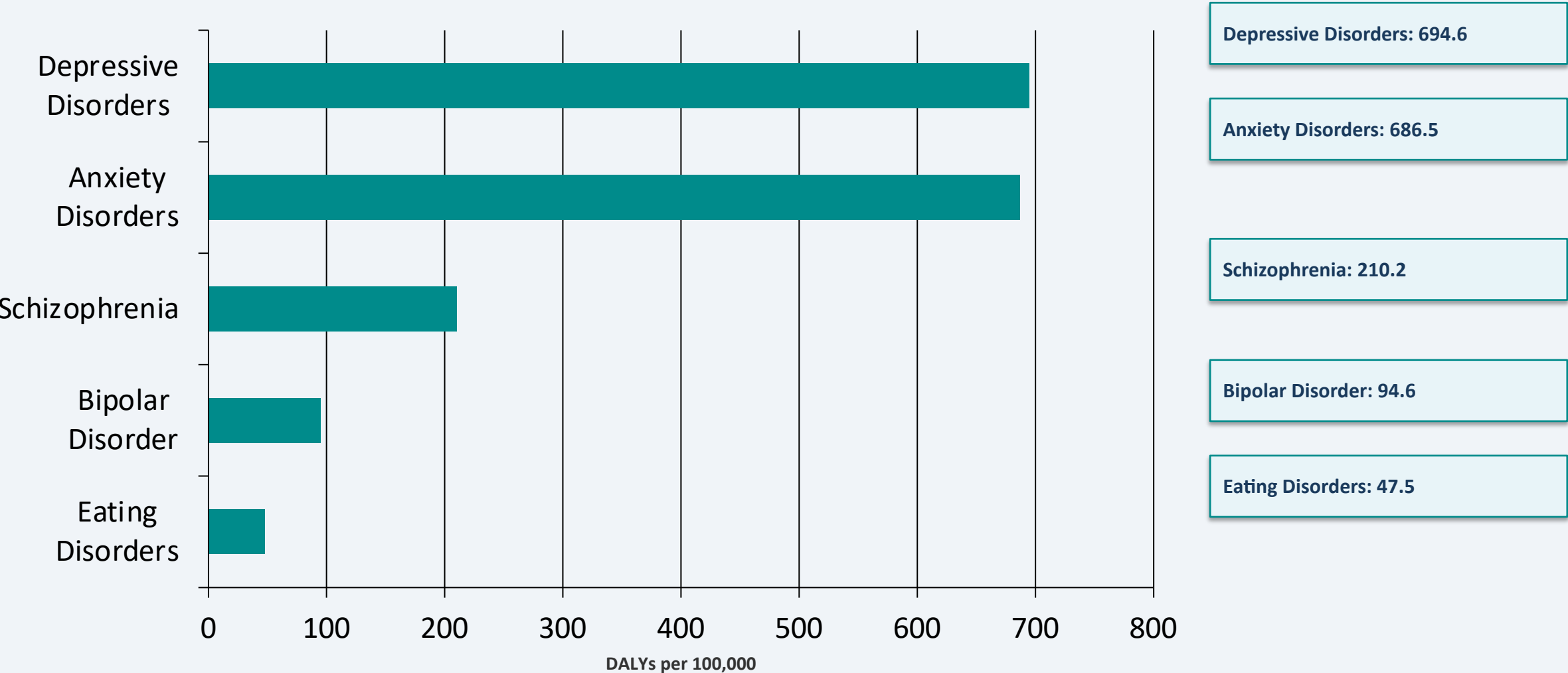
Men face major depression

Mental health conditions span from common (depression, anxiety) to less frequent but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar). These numbers reflect lifetime risk — not one-year prevalence.

Other conditions like schizophrenia and bipolar disorder affect fewer people but carry severe individual impact.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate Disease Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people — World, 2023

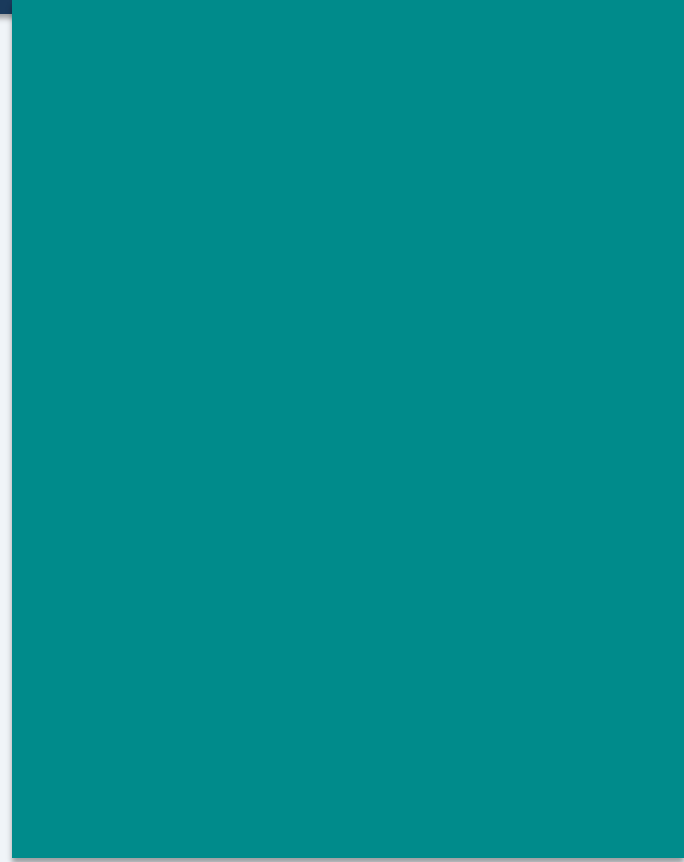


Source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease Study (2025)

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden

694.6

686.5



**Depressive
Disorders**



**Anxiety
Disorders**

Together they account for ~80% of total mental health DALYs across these five categories — dwarfing all others.

Schizophrenia and Bipolar: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact

210.2

DALYs per 100K

Schizophrenia

Severe disability, requires long-term care, affects ~20M people globally.

94.6

DALYs per 100K

Bipolar Disorder

Manic and depressive episodes cause significant functional impairment.

Contrast: Depression and Anxiety each exceed 680 DALYs per 100K — but individual severity varies widely.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

STIGMA

Many feel uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare providers or people they know.

ACCESS

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.

QUALITY

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality or inadequate.

UNDERREPORTING

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence.

Mental illnesses are treatable — yet significant barriers prevent many from receiving adequate care.

How People Cope: Diverse Strategies Across Cultures



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings; widely available but underused.



Faith & Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide; culturally significant coping mechanism.



Family & Friends

Talking to loved ones is a widely reported strategy across nearly all countries.

Policy interventions must account for this diversity — one-size-fits-all approaches are unlikely to succeed.

Key Takeaways

1

Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — nearly equal in magnitude (~695 and ~687 per 100K).

2

Schizophrenia and bipolar carry a disproportionate individual burden relative to their lower prevalence (210.2 and 94.6 per 100K).

3

Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate across much of the world, creating a persistent treatment gap.

4

Stigma suppresses help-seeking and accurate data — true prevalence is likely underestimated.

5

Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.